in the Meitei-dominated Imphal valley, and headed to the hills inhabited by their tribesmen.

Across this tiny northeastern state of India, the territorial divide is more deeply etched than ever. With boundaries marked in blood, civilians on both sides have taken up arms to protect their territory. Holed up in bunkers dug on the fringes of the villages, or taking positions behind sandbags, men and women, young and old, take turns to guard their homes and ethnic pride. The law and order machinery of the state has collapsed completely, so much so that people on both sides publicly wield their weapons, many of which are licensed shotguns, but also AK automatics and even sniper rifles.

So far, 179 people have been killed, nearly 500 injured and more than 60,000 displaced, 40,000 of whom are living in relief camps even now. Over 3,600 houses have been burnt, along with 321 places of worship. Untold atrocities, including rapes and beheadings, have taken place on both sides. And this despite the heavy security blanket in the state—it has the third-highest ratio of police personnel to civilians in India and large parts of it are under the Armed Forces Special Powers Act (AFSPA), 1958, with 161 companies of various central forces deployed. They include the Assam Rifles, a central paramilitary force, tasked to protect the state's border with Myanmar, as well as engage in counter-insurgency and preserve law and order when needed.

No stranger to violence, Manipur has seen decadal outbreaks of ethnic conflict ever since it was granted statehood in 1972, alongside episodic separatist insurgency against central authority. The 1993 Naga-Kuki clashes claimed 230 lives and displaced 100,000 people. Four years later, the Paites-Kuki conflict saw 352 dead and 13,000 displaced. Starting 2000, Irom Chanu Sharmila went on a 16-year-long fast unto death to get AFSPA lifted, alleging human rights atrocities by forces stationed there. The current crisis, however, is Manipur's worst in the past four decades.

The strife has only worsened even though Manipur has a 'double-engine' BJP government—at the Centre and in the state—with the Union home ministry constantly monitoring the situation. It took a viral video of two hapless Kuki women—being stripped naked and sexually molested by a group of armed Meitei men—to stir the collective conscience of the nation and for Prime Minister Narendra Modi to finally break his inexplicable silence. The leak, which is now being probed, ensured that five culprits were arrested, even as police took more than a month to register an FIR after the complaint was lodged. In Parliament, Opposition parties brought in a no-confidence motion against the Modi-led BJP government to force a discussion on the issue. A series of blunders—by the state government and the central authorities—has pushed Manipur to the brink, with a tragic and shameful deterioration in the law and order situation. Here, we list a few.



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BLUNDER 1: COMPLICITY OF THE STATE GOVERNMENT

The onset of the current round of violence can be traced to the solidarity march the All-Tribal Students' Union of Manipur called on May 3, which saw some incidents. The march was called to oppose the April 14 order of the Manipur High Court, in which it asked the state to send the Centre a recommendation on including the Meiteis among the Scheduled Tribes (STs). Behind the Meitei demand for this status and the tribal opposition lie Manipur's geography and demographic divisions. The state is clearly divided into the Imphal valley and the hill areas. Forty of the state's 60 assembly constituencies fall in the valley, which constitutes just over 11 per cent of the land area but is home to a majority of the Meiteis, who form 53 per cent of the state's population of 2.8 million, per the 2011 Census. The remaining 20 seats are distributed among the state's 10 hill districts, which are dominated by the Kukis and the Nagas, who together comprise 40 per cent of the population. The Nagas, who form 24 per cent, are dominant in seven districts and the Kukis, who are 16 per cent, mostly inhabit three districts (see graphic, *A Bloody Divide*). And though these districts account for nearly 90 per cent of the land area, most of it is densely forested and sparsely populated. The Naga and Kuki vote is influential in 10 seats each. The hill tribes